

OATH AND SWEARING IN THE WORDS OF JESUS

A Galilean Aramaic and Syriac Aramaic Study of Matthew 5:33–37

A Philological, Historical, Textual, and Theological Research Paper

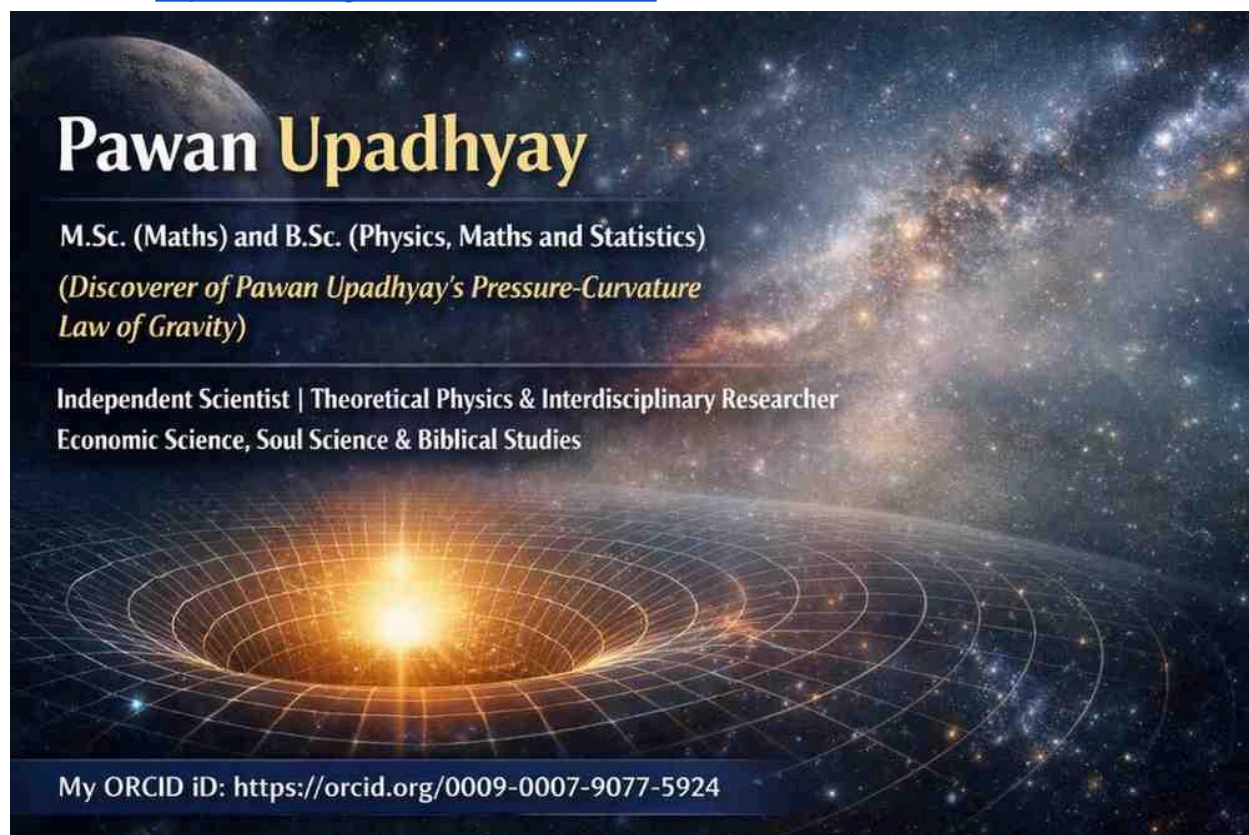
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Abstract

Matthew 5:33–37 contains one of the most important sayings of Jesus concerning truthful speech: “You shall not swear falsely,” followed by Jesus’ declaration, “But I say to you, Do not swear at all,” and concluding with the principle, “Let your word be, ‘Yes, yes,’ or ‘No, no.’” The passage has generated considerable discussion concerning the meaning of oath-taking, the language originally spoken by Jesus, and the relationship between the Greek Gospel of Matthew and the Aramaic traditions preserved in Syriac Christianity.

This study investigates the terminology of “**oath**” and “**to swear**” within the Aramaic linguistic environment relevant to the interpretation of Matthew 5:33–37. Particular attention is given to the distinction between first-century Galilean/Western Aramaic and later Syriac Aramaic. The study examines the Aramaic noun **mūmtā / mawmō’ā**, “oath,” and the verbal field represented by **√YMY**, “to swear,” together with the Syriac forms appearing in the Peshitta tradition. The Comprehensive Aramaic Lexicon provides evidence for the verb “to swear” and includes an Aramaic Gospel citation of Matthew 5:33 containing **lā te’ mā mūmtā d-šūqrā**, “do not swear an oath of falsehood.”

The study argues that Jesus’ teaching cannot adequately be understood merely as a prohibition against particular formulas of oath-taking. The literary context demonstrates a movement from **oath-taking to truthfulness**, from **external verbal guarantees to internal integrity**, and from **sacred formulas to reliable ordinary speech**. The repeated “Yes” and “No” of Matthew 5:37 represent the ethical culmination of the teaching.

The research further argues that the Syriac Peshitta is an important Aramaic witness but should not be presented uncritically as a verbatim transcript of Jesus’ Galilean speech. The linguistic environment of first-century Galilee was complex and multilingual, and scholarly discussion continues concerning the relative use of Aramaic, Hebrew, and Greek.

Keywords: Jesus, Matthew 5:33–37, oath, swear, Aramaic, Galilean Aramaic, Syriac, Peshitta, mūmtā, ymy, truthfulness, Sermon on the Mount.

1. Introduction

The Sermon on the Mount contains a series of teachings in which Jesus takes established commandments and traditional interpretations and presses them toward their deeper ethical meaning. Among these teachings is His statement concerning oaths:

“Again, you have heard that it was said to the ancients, ‘You shall not swear falsely, but you shall fulfill your oaths to the Lord.’ But I say to you, Do not swear at all...”

The passage is found in Matthew 5:33–37.

At the conclusion Jesus says:

“Let your word be, ‘Yes, yes,’ or ‘No, no’; anything more than these is from the evil one.”

The relationship between these two statements is essential. Jesus begins with the subject of **oaths**, but He ends with the subject of **ordinary speech**. The question therefore becomes larger than whether a particular oath is permissible. The fundamental question is whether the speaker's ordinary word can be trusted.

This research examines that question through an Aramaic linguistic lens.

The study concentrates particularly upon two concepts:

1. **Oath**
2. **To swear**

It asks how these concepts are represented in Aramaic, how they appear in Syriac Christian tradition, and what they contribute to understanding Jesus' teaching.

2. Research Problem

A major methodological problem exists in studies of the Aramaic words of Jesus.

It is common to encounter statements such as:

“This is exactly what Jesus said in Aramaic.”

Such statements can go beyond the surviving evidence.

The New Testament manuscripts preserve the Gospel of Matthew in Greek. Aramaic traditions, particularly Syriac Christianity, provide valuable witnesses to the Gospel but belong to different linguistic and textual traditions.

Therefore, a responsible study must distinguish:

A. Historical reconstruction of Jesus' probable linguistic environment

from

B. Surviving Syriac textual evidence

and from

C. The Greek textual form of Matthew.

These three forms of evidence should be compared, not simply equated.

3. Research Questions

This study addresses the following questions:

Question 1

What Aramaic vocabulary is associated with the concepts “oath” and “to swear”?

Question 2

What evidence exists for the verbal root associated with “to swear”?

Question 3

What is the significance of the Aramaic noun **mūmtā / mawmē’ā**?

Question 4

How does the Syriac Peshitta render Matthew 5:33–37?

Question 5

Can the Syriac wording be identified with the exact Galilean Aramaic words spoken by Jesus?

Question 6

What does the Aramaic linguistic evidence contribute to the interpretation of Jesus’ prohibition against oath-taking?

Question 7

Why does Jesus conclude the teaching with “Yes, yes” and “No, no”?

4. Methodology

This study employs four complementary methods.

4.1 Philological Method

The study examines the lexical meanings and grammatical functions of relevant Aramaic words.

4.2 Comparative-Linguistic Method

Galilean/Palestinian Aramaic evidence is compared with Syriac evidence without assuming that the dialects are identical.

4.3 Textual Method

Matthew 5:33–37 is studied as a literary unit, with attention to the sequence of Jesus' argument.

4.4 Historical Method

The linguistic evidence is evaluated within the multilingual environment of first-century Palestine.

This methodology is necessary because the question is not merely:

“What does one Aramaic word mean?”

The larger question is:

“How does the Aramaic linguistic world help us understand the historical and theological force of Jesus' teaching?”

5. The Linguistic Environment of First-Century Galilee

Jesus lived and taught in first-century Galilee.

It is therefore natural to investigate Aramaic when studying the historical background of His sayings. However, the linguistic situation should not be oversimplified.

Modern scholarship recognizes considerable linguistic diversity in Roman Palestine. Academic work on the linguistic environment of Galilee examines Hebrew, Aramaic, and Greek evidence rather than assuming that one language operated exclusively in every social context.

Consequently, the statement:

“Jesus spoke Aramaic”

does not settle every question concerning the exact dialect, vocabulary, or wording of an individual saying.

For Matthew 5:33–37, a responsible reconstruction should therefore be described as a **probable Aramaic reconstruction**, not as an independently preserved audio transcript of Jesus.

6. Aramaic “To Swear”: The Root √YMY

One of the most important lexical witnesses is the Aramaic root:

ܝܡܝ — √YMY

The Comprehensive Aramaic Lexicon gives **ymy** as a verb meaning:

“to swear.”

The database contains examples from different Aramaic textual traditions. It includes forms meaning “I swear to you” and examples involving swearing by something.

This is important because it demonstrates that the conceptual relationship between:

swearing

and

an oath

is deeply established within Aramaic linguistic usage.

The verb can also appear in constructions meaning:

“to swear by.”

This is particularly relevant to Matthew 5, because Jesus discusses people swearing by:

- heaven,
- earth,
- Jerusalem,

- their head.

Thus the Aramaic linguistic evidence confirms that oath-taking could be expressed through a verbal construction involving the thing by which the oath was made.

7. The Noun “Oath”

The corresponding nominal field contains forms represented in scholarly transliteration as:

mūmtā / mawmē’ā

and in Syriac script:

ܡܘܡܬܐ

The meaning is:

oath

The Comprehensive Aramaic Lexicon identifies forms represented as **mwm’h / mwmt’** with the meaning “**oath.**”

This is a crucial lexical distinction.

Verb

√**YMY**

= to swear

Noun

mūmtā / mawmē’ā

= oath

Therefore:

A person **swears** and makes an **oath**.

This distinction should be maintained in a scholarly translation and word study.

8. The Aramaic Expression “Oath of Falsehood”

Particularly significant evidence occurs in the Aramaic Gospel citation preserved in the Comprehensive Aramaic Lexicon.

Matthew 5:33 is represented as:

ܠܐ ܬܝܡܝܢ ܕܫܘܩܪܐ ܠܡܬܐ

Transliteration

lā te’ mā mūmtā d-šūqrā

Approximate translation

“Do not swear an oath of falsehood.”

The important vocabulary is:

te’ mā

= swear

mūmtā

= oath

šūqrā

= falsehood/deception

The Comprehensive Aramaic Lexicon specifically records this Gospel citation under the Aramaic verb meaning “to swear.”

This is one of the strongest pieces of evidence for the present study because it places the vocabulary of **swearing + oath + falsehood** directly within an Aramaic form of Matthew 5:33.

9. Syriac Peshitta Evidence

The Syriac Peshitta provides another important witness.

In the Syriac tradition, the noun for “oath” occurs in Matthew 5:33 in a form corresponding to:

ܡܘܡܬܐܬܟܗ

mūmtākh

“your oath.”

This reflects the same fundamental lexical field.

The significance of this evidence is twofold.

First, it demonstrates that Syriac Christian tradition preserved the terminology of oath-taking in Aramaic.

Second, it allows comparison between the Greek Matthew and an Aramaic/Syriac textual tradition.

However, this evidence must be interpreted historically.

The Peshitta is a Syriac literary tradition. Syriac is an Aramaic language, but Syriac should not simply be substituted for first-century Galilean Aramaic.

10. “Do Not Swear at All”

The Syriac wording of Matthew 5:34 contains the emphatic expression:

ܠܐ ܬܝܡܢ ܥܠ ܕܢܝܢܐ

lā te’ mūn sāk

The basic sense is:

“Do not swear at all.”

The negative particle **lā** introduces the prohibition.

The verb expresses the act of swearing.

The additional term strengthens the prohibition toward the sense of:

at all / entirely / in any way.

This is important because Jesus does not merely prohibit dishonest oaths.

The wording presents a broader challenge to oath-dependent speech.

11. The Greek Text and Aramaic Comparison

The Greek text of Matthew uses the vocabulary of:

ὀμνύω — omnyō

to swear

and

ὄρκος — horkos

oath.

Thus the Greek and Aramaic traditions contain corresponding lexical fields.

A simplified comparison is:

Concept	Greek	Aramaic/Syriac
to swear	ὀμνύω	Aramaic ܐܡܝܢ / Syriac forms
oath	ὄρκος	ܠܐ ܡܝܢ
falsehood	ψεῦδος / related vocabulary	ܠܝܚܬܐ
yes	ναί	ܝܥܢ
no	οὐ	ܠܐ

The comparison demonstrates that the conceptual structure of the saying is compatible across the traditions.

But lexical correspondence does not by itself prove that the Greek text is a translation of an original Aramaic document.

12. The Meaning of “Yes”

Matthew 5:37 concludes:

“Let your word be, ‘Yes, yes.’”

The Aramaic lexical tradition is particularly interesting here.

The Comprehensive Aramaic Lexicon records:

ܐܝܢ — ’ēn

with the meaning:

“yes.”

It also records examples of ’ēn in oath-related formulations.

This creates an important conceptual connection.

Jesus’ teaching moves from:

oath

to:

yes/no speech.

The ordinary “yes” becomes morally sufficient.

The speaker does not need an elaborate oath to guarantee the truthfulness of his answer.

13. The Meaning of “No”

The corresponding negative is:

𐤀 — lā

The basic meaning is:

no / not.

Jesus therefore establishes a simple verbal pattern:

Yes — yes.

No — no.

This is not merely a grammatical construction.

It is an ethical standard.

The person should not need to multiply words in order to establish credibility.

14. The Literary Structure of Matthew 5:33–37

The passage can be arranged structurally as follows:

A. Traditional command

“You shall not swear falsely.”

B. Obligation

“You shall fulfill your oaths to the Lord.”

C. Jesus’ intensification

“Do not swear at all.”

D. Examples

Do not swear by:

- heaven,

- earth,
- Jerusalem,
- your head.

E. Human limitation

You cannot control even one hair of your head.

F. Positive replacement

“Let your word be Yes, yes; No, no.”

G. Final warning

Anything beyond this belongs to the realm of evil.

This structure demonstrates that Jesus is not simply introducing another legal restriction.

He is transforming the entire concept of truthful speech.

15. Why Does Jesus Mention Heaven?

Jesus says:

“Do not swear by heaven, because it is the throne of God.”

The argument is theological.

Heaven is not an independent object that human beings can use as a verbal guarantee.

It belongs to God.

Therefore, invoking heaven does not create a neutral guarantee outside God's authority.

16. Why Does Jesus Mention the Earth?

Jesus continues:

“Nor by the earth, because it is the footstool of His feet.”

Again, the earth belongs within God's sovereignty.

The person cannot escape divine accountability by changing the object invoked in an oath.

17. Why Does Jesus Mention Jerusalem?

Jesus says:

“Nor by Jerusalem, because it is the city of the great King.”

Jerusalem possesses religious significance, but that significance does not make it an independent mechanism for guaranteeing human speech.

The city belongs to the King.

Therefore, the oath remains ultimately connected with God.

18. Why Does Jesus Mention the Head?

Jesus then moves from cosmic realities to the individual:

“Neither shall you swear by your head, because you cannot make one hair white or black.”

The argument becomes intensely personal.

Human beings do not even possess complete control over their own bodies.

Therefore, a person should not speak as though he possesses absolute authority over reality.

The oath can become an expression of exaggerated human confidence.

Jesus rejects that posture.

19. Oath-Taking and Human Pride

The passage therefore has a deeper anthropological dimension.

The person who repeatedly swears may be attempting to establish his own credibility by force of language.

Jesus instead teaches humility.

The speaker should simply tell the truth.

The greater the need for verbal guarantees, the more serious the question becomes:

Why is ordinary speech not enough?

Jesus' answer is to restore the integrity of ordinary speech.

20. Oath and Falsehood

The relationship between oath and falsehood is especially important.

An oath does not automatically make a statement true.

A dishonest person can swear.

Therefore:

Swearing is not equivalent to truthfulness.

A person can say:

“I swear...”

and still lie.

Jesus' teaching attacks precisely this false confidence in the power of verbal formulas.

21. Religious Language Cannot Sanctify Falsehood

A particularly important theological principle emerges.

Adding God's name to a statement does not transform falsehood into truth.

Using:

- heaven,
- earth,
- Jerusalem,
- one's own head,

does not make a dishonest statement honest.

Jesus therefore shifts the focus from the **formula** to the **heart**.

The issue is not:

“Which oath is strongest?”

The issue is:

“Is the person telling the truth?”

22. The Principle of Integrity

Jesus' alternative is extraordinarily simple:

“Yes, yes.”

“No, no.”

This establishes an ethical principle:

The word itself should carry truth.

The disciple does not need to manipulate another person's confidence.

The disciple speaks truthfully.

This makes Jesus' teaching relevant far beyond ancient oath practices.

It concerns:

- business,
- contracts,

- testimony,
 - promises,
 - family relationships,
 - religious speech,
 - political speech,
 - academic integrity,
 - personal relationships.
-

23. Oaths and Modern Society

Modern society contains many mechanisms for guaranteeing statements:

- signatures,
- contracts,
- affidavits,
- sworn testimony,
- legal declarations,
- certificates,
- promises,
- institutional guarantees.

Jesus' teaching does not necessarily eliminate every legal institution.

Rather, it challenges the moral assumption that a person may be careless with ordinary truth because a formal declaration exists.

The deeper principle remains:

Formal confirmation should not replace personal integrity.

24. Galilean Aramaic Reconstruction

Any attempt to reconstruct Jesus' original Galilean Aramaic wording must be presented cautiously.

The surviving evidence does not provide a first-century manuscript containing Matthew 5:33–37 in Jesus' own handwriting or a contemporary recording of His speech.

Therefore, a reconstructed form can only be described as:

a proposed linguistic reconstruction

rather than:

the certain original sentence.

This distinction is especially important in academic writing.

The study of Galilean Aramaic is nevertheless valuable because it provides a historical linguistic environment within which Jesus' sayings can be examined.

Recent scholarship continues to examine how Aramaic sayings attributed to Jesus can be reconstructed and what evidence can legitimately support such reconstructions.

25. A Proposed Aramaic Conceptual Reconstruction

On the basis of the lexical evidence, the conceptual structure of Matthew 5:33 can be represented approximately as:

“Do not swear an oath of falsehood.”

The important components are:

to swear

→ verbal action

oath

→ solemn declaration

falsehood

→ moral violation.

This should not be confused with claiming that this exact reconstruction is the historically certain sentence Jesus pronounced.

Rather, it demonstrates how the concepts could be expressed within the Aramaic linguistic environment.

26. The Syriac Witness Is Valuable but Not Identical to Galilean

This distinction deserves special emphasis.

Galilean Aramaic

This refers to the Western Aramaic linguistic environment of Galilee.

Syriac Aramaic

This developed as a major literary language of Christian communities farther east.

Peshitta

This represents a Syriac textual tradition of the Bible.

Therefore:

Galilean Aramaic ≠ Syriac Aramaic

although:

Galilean Aramaic and Syriac = related Aramaic languages/traditions.

This distinction protects the research from anachronism.

27. The Importance of the Comprehensive Aramaic Lexicon

The Comprehensive Aramaic Lexicon is particularly valuable for this investigation because it is designed to document Aramaic across many dialects and historical periods. Its database contains millions of lexically parsed words and tens of thousands of headwords. The project itself cautions that it is a work in progress, which is important when using it for scholarly research.

For the present study, its value lies particularly in documenting:

- the verb **ymy**, “to swear”;

- oath vocabulary;
- Syriac forms;
- Palestinian/Jewish Aramaic evidence;
- Gospel citations;
- examples of oath formulations.

The lexical evidence therefore provides a much firmer foundation than an unsupported claim about a hypothetical original Aramaic sentence.

28. Semantic Field of “Swearing”

The Aramaic semantic field is broader than merely saying:

“I promise.”

To swear may involve:

- making a solemn declaration,
- invoking a person or authority,
- swearing by something,
- accepting an obligation,
- establishing the truth of a statement,
- making a vow.

The exact meaning depends upon grammatical construction and context.

Therefore, a dictionary gloss such as:

“to swear”

does not exhaust the semantic significance of the verb.

29. The Difference Between an Oath and a Promise

A useful distinction should be maintained.

Promise

A person commits himself to an action.

Oath

A person makes a solemn declaration or commitment, often invoking a higher authority or sacred reality as guarantee.

Jesus' teaching addresses the second concept but reaches toward the first.

His solution is not merely:

“Do not make promises.”

Instead, it is:

Make your ordinary word reliable.

30. The Ethical Logic of Jesus' Teaching

The logic can be summarized:

Step 1

A person makes a statement.

Step 2

The person feels the statement requires additional credibility.

Step 3

The person introduces an oath.

Step 4

The person invokes heaven, earth, Jerusalem, or another object.

Step 5

Jesus exposes the weakness of this approach.

Step 6

Jesus replaces oath-dependent credibility with truthful speech.

Therefore:

The stronger solution is not a stronger oath but a stronger character.

31. Jesus and the Inner Person

This fits the wider Sermon on the Mount.

Jesus repeatedly moves from outward conduct to inward character.

The pattern is:

Murder → anger

Adultery → lust

Retaliation → non-retaliation

Enemy → love

Oath → truthful speech

The Sermon therefore presents a consistent ethical philosophy.

Jesus is not satisfied with external compliance.

He seeks transformed character.

32. Oath-Taking as a Problem of Trust

At its deepest level, oath-taking exists because human beings experience uncertainty about another person's word.

The oath is designed to increase confidence.

But Jesus proposes something better:

character-based trust.

If people are truthful, society requires fewer verbal guarantees.

Thus:

Integrity creates trust.

Trust reduces the need for elaborate guarantees.

Jesus' teaching therefore has a social as well as religious dimension.

33. The Meaning of “Anything More”

Matthew 5:37 says:

“Anything more than these is from the evil one.”

The statement is severe.

It suggests that the multiplication of words can become dangerous.

More words do not necessarily mean more truth.

Sometimes additional language is used to obscure rather than reveal.

Jesus therefore advocates verbal simplicity.

Yes.

No.

Truth does not need theatrical decoration.

34. “Yes, Yes” as a Truth Formula

The repetition:

“Yes, yes”

can be understood as emphasis.

Likewise:

“No, no”

reinforces certainty.

The speaker does not need to invoke another authority.

The speaker's own truthful word is sufficient.

The ethical principle is:

Let your speech possess integrity before God and before other human beings.

35. Theological Interpretation

From a Christian theological perspective, Jesus' teaching can be organized around three virtues.

35.1 Truth

The disciple must speak truthfully.

35.2 Integrity

The external word must correspond to the internal intention.

35.3 Humility

The speaker must recognize that human beings do not control everything they invoke.

Together these produce trustworthy speech.

36. Historical-Linguistic Caution

Several conclusions should therefore be avoided.

We should not claim:

“The Syriac Peshitta is exactly what Jesus spoke.”

That conclusion exceeds the evidence.

We should not claim:

“Every Aramaic form found in the Peshitta is first-century Galilean Aramaic.”

Syriac and Galilean Aramaic are different traditions.

We should not claim:

“The Greek Gospel must necessarily be a translation from Aramaic.”

The question of the composition and linguistic sources of the Gospels is more complicated. Scholarship includes arguments for significant Greek use in first-century Palestine.

We can responsibly claim:

Aramaic was an important part of the linguistic environment relevant to Jesus, Aramaic traditions preserve valuable evidence for the conceptual and lexical background of His sayings, and Syriac provides an important comparative witness.

37. Major Findings

This research produces several major findings.

Finding 1

Aramaic possesses established vocabulary for the concepts of **swearing** and **oath**.

Finding 2

The root √**YMY** is documented with the meaning “**to swear**.”

Finding 3

Aramaic/Syriac forms represented by **mūmtā** / **mawmē’ā** mean “**oath**.”

Finding 4

An Aramaic Gospel citation of Matthew 5:33 explicitly combines the concepts:

“swear + oath + falsehood.”

Finding 5

The Syriac tradition confirms the importance of this lexical field but should not automatically be identified with Jesus' original Galilean wording.

Finding 6

Jesus' teaching moves from the prohibition of false oath-taking toward a broader demand for truthful ordinary speech.

Finding 7

The climax, “Yes, yes; No, no,” indicates that Jesus' ultimate concern is integrity.

38. A Proposed Conceptual Translation

Rather than attempting to manufacture an allegedly certain “original Aramaic Jesus sentence,” the safest reconstruction is conceptual:

“You have heard that it was said, ‘You shall not swear falsely, but you shall fulfill your oaths to the Lord.’ But I say to you: do not swear at all. Let your word simply be Yes, yes, or No, no.”

This preserves the structure of the teaching without claiming more linguistic certainty than the evidence permits.

39. Jesus’ Full Teaching in Context

The complete argument can therefore be paraphrased:

Do not build your credibility upon oaths. Heaven belongs to God. The earth belongs to God. Jerusalem belongs to God. Even your own body is beyond your absolute control. Therefore, do not use sacred realities as verbal instruments to strengthen questionable speech. Instead, become a person whose ordinary word is trustworthy. When you mean yes, say yes. When you mean no, say no.

This captures the theological and ethical movement of the passage.

40. Conclusion

Matthew 5:33–37 is fundamentally a teaching about **truthfulness**.

The Aramaic evidence enriches our understanding of this passage by revealing a well-developed linguistic field surrounding:

to swear

and

oath.

The root √**YMY** provides evidence for the verbal concept “to swear,” while forms represented by **mūmtā / mawmē ā** represent the noun “oath.” The Aramaic Gospel evidence associated with Matthew 5:33 is especially significant because it places “swear,” “oath,” and “falsehood” together in one expression.

The Syriac Peshitta further demonstrates how an Aramaic Christian textual tradition expresses Jesus’ teaching. Yet the Peshitta should be treated as a Syriac witness, not automatically as a verbatim transcript of Jesus’ first-century Galilean speech.

The central theological insight remains clear.

Jesus does not merely ask:

“Which oath should you use?”

He asks a much deeper question:

“Can your word be trusted?”

His answer is:

“Let your word be, ‘Yes, yes,’ or ‘No, no.’”

The teaching therefore moves from **oath to integrity**, from **formula to character**, from **external guarantee to internal truthfulness**, and from **religious language to moral responsibility**.

The greatest oath is unnecessary when the speaker is truthful.

The strongest guarantee is a trustworthy character.

And the simplest Christian principle is therefore:

Let Yes be Yes, and No be No.

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Final Research Statement

The evidence permits a strong conclusion about the **semantic and ethical relationship between oath-taking and truthful speech**, but it does not permit absolute certainty concerning the exact Galilean Aramaic sentence Jesus pronounced.

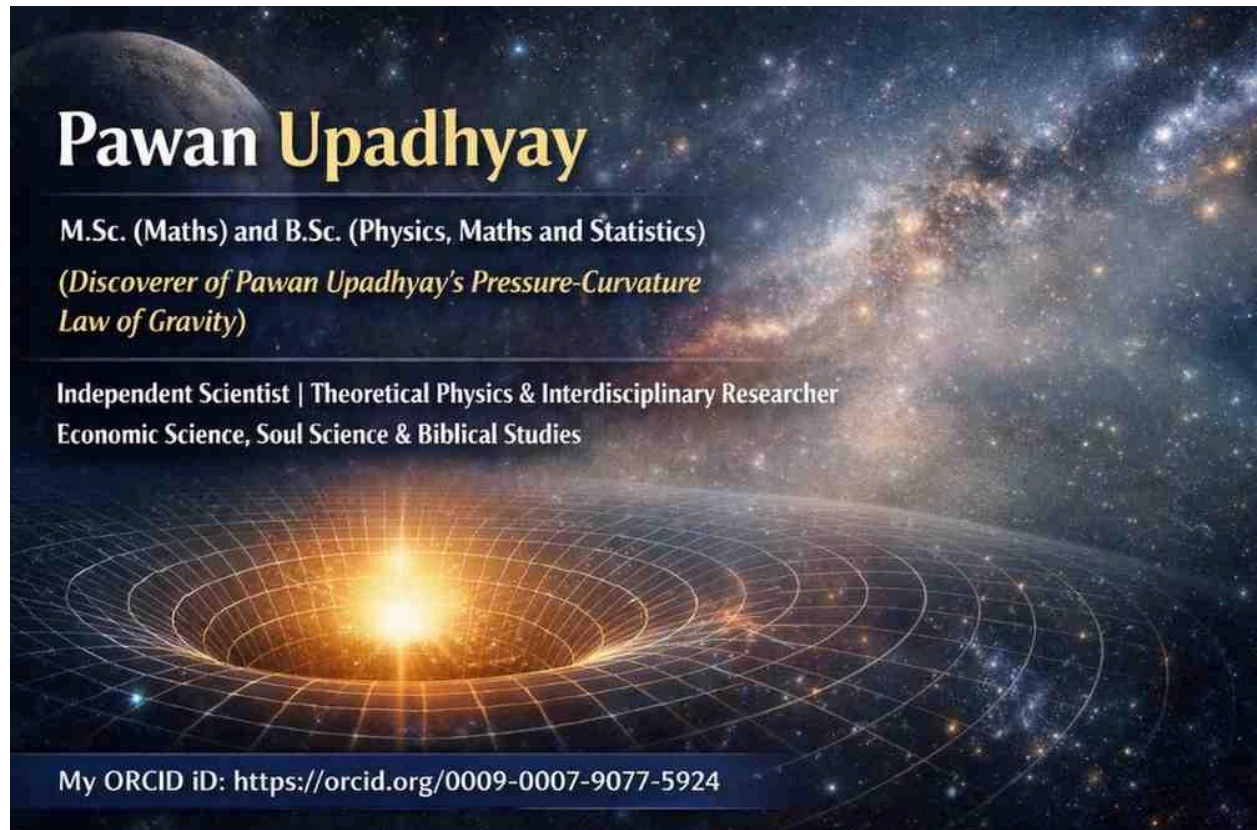
Accordingly, the most academically responsible position is:

The Aramaic linguistic evidence strongly illuminates the historical and conceptual background of Jesus' teaching on oaths, while the Syriac Peshitta provides an important Aramaic textual witness. However, reconstruction of Jesus' exact first-century Galilean wording remains a matter of historical-linguistic probability rather than direct textual certainty.

This distinction does not weaken the teaching.

It strengthens the research by allowing the linguistic evidence, historical evidence, and theological interpretation to remain properly distinguished.

“Do Not Swear at All”: Jesus’ Teaching on Oaths in Galilean and Syriac Aramaic



https://archive.org/details/@pawan_upadhyay

Introduction

Among the most challenging sayings of Jesus is His teaching about oaths:

“But I say to you, Do not swear at all.”

— Matthew 5:34

These words occur within Jesus’ Sermon on the Mount, where He addresses truthfulness, integrity, and the proper use of speech. The teaching begins with the traditional command concerning oaths and culminates in one of Jesus’ most concise ethical principles:

“Let your word be, ‘Yes, yes,’ or ‘No, no.’”

— Matthew 5:37

The linguistic background becomes especially interesting when this passage is examined through the world of **Aramaic**, the language environment in which Jesus lived and taught.

Jesus lived in first-century Galilee, where forms of Western Aramaic were spoken. The surviving Syriac Christian tradition, meanwhile, preserves an important Aramaic witness to the Gospel through the **Peshitta**. These two should not simply be equated: Galilean Aramaic and Syriac are related Aramaic traditions, but they are not identical dialects.

Nevertheless, comparison between the Galilean linguistic environment and Syriac evidence can illuminate the vocabulary and conceptual world behind Jesus' statement.

1. Jesus' Complete Teaching on Oaths

Jesus' statement should be read as a complete unit rather than as the isolated sentence, "Do not swear."

Matthew 5:33–37 presents the following progression:

"Again, you have heard that it was said to the ancients, 'You shall not swear falsely, but you shall fulfill your oaths to the Lord.'

But I say to you, Do not swear at all, neither by heaven, because it is the throne of God;

nor by the earth, because it is the footstool of His feet; nor by Jerusalem, because it is the city of the great King.

Neither shall you swear by your head, because you cannot make one hair white or black.

But let your word be, 'Yes, yes,' or 'No, no'; anything more than these is from the evil one."

The movement of the teaching is significant:

Oath → Sacred object → Human inability → Simple truthful speech

Jesus does not merely discuss vocabulary. He addresses the moral condition of the speaker.

2. The Aramaic Concept of "Oath"

One important Aramaic noun associated with an oath is:

ܡܘܡܬܐ — **mūmtā**

This means:

- oath
- solemn oath
- sworn declaration
- an undertaking made under oath

The related form appears in Syriac as ܐܡܬܐ and in forms such as ܕܐܡܬܐ, meaning “your oath.”

This vocabulary is important for Matthew 5:33 because the Peshitta uses the expression involving **mūmtā**, “oath.”

The concept therefore involves something considerably more serious than an ordinary casual promise. An oath is a formal declaration intended to establish the truthfulness or seriousness of what a person says.

3. The Aramaic Verb “To Swear”

The Aramaic linguistic field also contains the verbal concept of **swearing or taking an oath**.

The Comprehensive Aramaic Lexicon records the Aramaic root √**YMY (ܝܡܝ)** with the meaning “**to swear**.”

This gives us an important semantic relationship:

ܝܡܝ — y-m-y → to swear

and

ܡܘܡܬܐ — mūmtā → oath

The relationship between the verbal action and the noun is straightforward:

to swear → an oath

A person **swears**, and the resulting solemn declaration is an **oath**.

This linguistic distinction is important because Jesus' teaching contains both concepts: the act of swearing and the oath itself.

4. Syriac Aramaic and the Peshitta

The Syriac Peshitta provides an especially valuable Aramaic witness to Matthew 5.

In Matthew 5:33, the Peshitta contains:

ܡܘܡܬܐ

mūmtākh

meaning:

“your oath”

The passage uses the vocabulary of oath-taking and falsehood together.

The sense is approximately:

“You shall not swear falsely, but you shall fulfill your oath to the Lord.”

This reflects the ethical background of Jesus' teaching.

The issue is not simply the pronunciation of an oath. The deeper question is whether a person's speech can be trusted.

5. “Do Not Swear at All”

The Syriac Peshitta's Matthew 5:34 contains:

ܠܐ ܬܐܡܪ ܫܐܬܐ ܠܐ

lā te' mūn sāk

The sense is:

“Do not swear at all.”

The word ܠܐ (**lā**) means “not” or “do not,” while the verbal form expresses the action of swearing.

The presence of ܫܐܬܐ (**sāk**) strengthens the negative statement toward the sense of:

“not at all,”

“in no way,”

“never.”

Thus the Peshitta makes Jesus' prohibition very emphatic.

6. Why Does Jesus Say “Do Not Swear”?

At first glance, Jesus' statement may appear to prohibit every form of oath under every circumstance.

But the surrounding context gives us the key to understanding the teaching.

Jesus says:

“Let your word be, ‘Yes, yes,’ or ‘No, no.’”

This explains the purpose of the command.

Jesus is attacking the practice of making ordinary truthfulness dependent upon increasingly elaborate guarantees.

A person says:

“I swear by heaven.”

Another says:

“I swear by the earth.”

Another says:

“I swear by Jerusalem.”

Another invokes his own head.

Jesus exposes the weakness behind this practice.

If a person's ordinary word is true, why must he continually attach sacred guarantees to it?

7. Jesus Moves from Oaths to Character

The most important point of the passage is therefore ethical rather than merely grammatical.

Jesus wants a person whose:

Yes means Yes.

And whose:

No means No.

The trustworthy person does not need to construct an elaborate oath to convince others that he is telling the truth.

The quality of his character makes his word reliable.

This produces a powerful principle:

Truth should exist before the oath, not because of the oath.

An oath cannot transform a dishonest person into an honest person.

If someone lies, adding religious language does not make the lie true.

If someone is truthful, his ordinary speech should already be trustworthy.

8. Galilean Aramaic Perspective

Jesus' historical setting was Galilee.

Therefore, when attempting to reconstruct what Jesus might have said in His everyday speech, scholars must consider **Galilean/Jewish Palestinian Aramaic**, rather than simply taking later Syriac and declaring it to be Jesus' exact wording.

This distinction is essential.

We should distinguish three things:

1. Jesus' historical spoken language

Jesus most likely taught primarily in a form of Palestinian/Western Aramaic appropriate to His Galilean environment, while also interacting with Hebrew and Greek.

2. Later Aramaic Gospel traditions

Syriac Christianity preserved the Gospel in Syriac, an Eastern Aramaic literary tradition.

3. The Peshitta

The Peshitta is therefore an important Syriac witness to the Gospel, but it is not automatically a word-for-word transcript of Jesus' original Galilean speech.

This caution makes the study stronger rather than weaker.

9. The Difference Between Galilean and Syriac Aramaic

“Aramaic” is not the name of a single unchanging language.

It represents a large family of languages and dialects that developed over many centuries.

Galilean Aramaic belonged to the Western Aramaic environment.

Syriac developed as an important literary form of Eastern Aramaic.

Consequently, the following principle should be maintained:

Syriac can illuminate the Aramaic conceptual and linguistic world of the Gospel, but it should not automatically be retrojected as Jesus' exact Galilean wording.

This is particularly important in serious research on the historical words of Jesus.

10. “Oath” and “Swearing”: Two Different Ideas

A useful distinction is:

OATH

ܡܡܬܐ — **mūmtā**

The noun refers to the solemn declaration itself.

TO SWEAR

The Aramaic verbal vocabulary refers to the act of making such a declaration.

Therefore:

Oath = the solemn declaration

Swearing = the act of making the declaration

Jesus' teaching addresses both.

He challenges not merely the existence of an oath but the human tendency to use oaths as a substitute for genuine integrity.

11. Jesus' Teaching and the Problem of Falsehood

Matthew 5:33 begins with:

“You shall not swear falsely...”

This is crucial.

The biblical problem is not simply vocabulary. It is **falsehood**.

A person may use extremely religious language while simultaneously deceiving another person.

Jesus therefore takes the commandment against false oaths to a deeper level.

He essentially says:

Do not build a system in which ordinary speech can be dishonest while an oath is considered trustworthy.

Instead:

Make ordinary speech truthful.

12. “Yes, Yes” and “No, No”

The climax of the passage is Matthew 5:37:

“Let your word be, ‘Yes, yes,’ or ‘No, no.’”

This is one of the clearest expressions of Jesus' teaching about integrity.

The word of a disciple should be sufficient.

If the answer is yes:

Yes.

If the answer is no:

No.

There should be no need for deception, manipulation, exaggeration, or unnecessary religious formulas.

Jesus is creating a culture of **truthful speech**.

13. The Spiritual Dimension

The teaching also reveals something about the relationship between human beings and God.

Jesus says that heaven is God's throne and the earth is His footstool.

Therefore, when people swear by heaven or earth, they are invoking realities that ultimately belong to God.

The person who swears cannot separate his oath from God's creation.

Jesus' argument effectively removes the possibility of using sacred things as verbal escape routes.

You cannot say:

"I did not really mean it because I swore by something less important."

Everything belongs to God.

Therefore, the solution is not to find a more sophisticated formula.

The solution is truthful speech.

14. The Deeper Meaning of Jesus' Command

Jesus' teaching can be summarized in four principles:

1. Do not use oaths to manufacture credibility.

A person's character should establish credibility.

2. Do not use religious language to disguise falsehood.

Invoking God or sacred things cannot make a lie true.

3. Make ordinary speech trustworthy.

"Yes" should genuinely mean yes.

"No" should genuinely mean no.

4. Let integrity replace verbal manipulation.

The disciple of Jesus should not need complicated formulas to establish honesty.

15. Connection with the Broader Teaching of Jesus

This teaching fits naturally with Jesus' wider emphasis on the condition of the heart.

Jesus repeatedly moves beyond external religious observance toward internal righteousness.

He teaches about:

- anger rather than merely murder,
- lust rather than merely adultery,
- reconciliation rather than merely sacrifice,
- love of enemies rather than merely love of friends,
- generosity rather than public display,
- truthful speech rather than elaborate oaths.

Thus, Matthew 5:33–37 belongs to a larger pattern:

Jesus transforms external religious rules into matters of inner character.

The question is not:

“What oath am I permitted to use?”

The deeper question is:

“Can my word be trusted?”

16. A Linguistic Summary

The relevant Aramaic vocabulary can therefore be summarized as follows:

Concept	Aramaic/Syriac	Transliteration	Basic meaning
Oath	ܡܘܡܬܐ	<i>mūmtā</i>	oath
Your oath	ܟܝܢܐܡܬܐܟܝܢ	<i>mūmtākh</i>	your oath
To swear	ܝܡܝܢܐ	<i>y-m-y</i>	to swear
Do not swear	ܠܐ ܬܝܡܝܢ	<i>lā te`mūn</i>	do not swear
Your word	ܡܠܬܟܝܢ	<i>melltkūn</i>	your word/speech
Yes	ܝܝܢ	<i>ēn</i>	yes
No	ܠܐ	<i>lā</i>	no/not

The exact reconstructed Galilean pronunciation should be treated cautiously because we do not possess an audio recording or an original first-century Aramaic manuscript containing Jesus' complete Sermon on the Mount.

Conclusion

Jesus' teaching, **“Do not swear at all,”** is ultimately a teaching about **truthfulness**.

The Aramaic vocabulary helps us see the distinction between an **oath** and the **act of swearing**, while the Syriac Peshitta preserves an important early Christian Aramaic tradition of the Gospel.

But the greatest significance of the passage is not linguistic.

Jesus wants His followers to become people whose words can be trusted without elaborate oaths.

The ideal is beautifully simple:

Yes should mean Yes.

No should mean No.

A truthful person does not need to decorate his statement with an oath.

A dishonest person cannot make falsehood true merely by invoking God, heaven, earth, Jerusalem, or anything else.

Jesus therefore takes the subject of oaths and transforms it into a profound teaching about **integrity, truth, responsibility, and the condition of the human heart.**

The ultimate message is this:

Do not make your oath stronger; make your character truthful.

And that is why Jesus' teaching about the oath leads directly to His teaching about the word.